

Allergies



Nettle
(*Urtica dioica*)

Allergies often develop when the body's immune system overreacts to an external irritant such as pollen, insect stings, and certain plants, or internal substances such as chemicals and foods. The allergens trigger a reaction in those who have a built-in or natural sensitivity. In the long term, allergies are treated by both reducing contact with allergens (if known) and working to reduce the body's oversensitivity. Herbal remedies can bring relief to some allergic states and are helpful in gradually reducing allergic reactions. See also *Skin Rashes*, p. 303.

❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Life-threatening allergies, such as asthma. Consult a professional practitioner prior to taking any herbal remedies for such conditions
- Any allergy that shows signs of deterioration after taking an herbal remedy

🌿 Allergic Rhinitis, Including Hay Fever

Allergic rhinitis is an umbrella term for allergic reactions to irritants such as pollution, dust, or pollen. Allergic rhinitis may occur year round, while hay fever is usually caused by seasonal grass or pollens. Symptoms include sneezing; copious nasal mucus; sinus congestion; watery, irritated eyes; and even asthmatic wheezing. Self-treatment will help relieve mild conditions, but for severe attacks, consult a professional practitioner who can prescribe herbs such as ma huang (*Ephedra sinica*, p. 95). See also *Congestion*, *Sinus Problems*, & *Earache*, p. 312.

Diet

Reduce your intake of or cut out mucus-forming foods such as dairy, eggs, sugar, white flour, fatty foods, and alcohol.

General Remedies

Herbs Nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146), elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132)

Remedy Make a nettle infusion. Take 1½–2½ cups (450–600 ml) a day for 3 months at a time. Alternatively, make an infusion with 1 tsp of each herb to 1¼ cups (300 ml) of water and take daily for 3 months at a time.

Herb Baical skullcap (*Scutellaria baicalensis*, p. 134)

Remedy Make a decoction from the herb and take 1¼ cups (300 ml) a day.

Hay Fever

Herb Elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132)

Remedy Make an infusion and take 1¼–1½ cups (300–450 ml) a day. Take for a few months before, as well as during, the hay fever season.

Allergic Rhinitis with Congestion

Herbs Eyebright (*Euphrasia* spp., p. 209), common plantain (*Plantago major*, p. 251), goldenrod (*Solidago virgaurea*, p. 271), boneset (*Eupatorium perfoliatum*, p. 208)

Remedy Make an infusion with one or a mixture of all of the herbs and drink up to 1½ cups a day.

Note Use this remedy especially for copious, watery mucus.

Herbs Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165), elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Take 1 tsp of equal parts of each tincture 3 times daily with warm water.

Note Use this remedy especially for thick yellow/green mucus and sinus congestion.

🌿 Eczema

Characterized by red, inflamed skin, eczema causes irritation, flaking, scaling, and tiny blisters. Although it is often the result of an allergic reaction to certain substances, eczema can also be inherited, result from prolonged contact with an irritant, or it may simply appear for an unknown reason. It is best to consult a professional practitioner as eczema is difficult to self-treat. However, the following remedies, taken for at least a week, can bring relief. Two remedies may be used at once. Chickweed reduces soreness or itchiness, and oats can be used to impart a soothing, emollient effect to bathwater. See also *Skin Rashes*, p. 303.

Self-help

To avoid scratching, cover the affected area with an absorbent, non-irritating material such as cotton.

❗ **General caution** If there is no improvement, or if the condition deteriorates, consult a professional practitioner.

General Remedies

Herbs Peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114), chickweed (*Stellaria media*, p. 272)

Remedy 1 Make peppermint lotion by infusing 1 tsp of herb to ¾ cup (150 ml) of water. Leave for 10 minutes, then strain and cool. Use to wash gently over the affected skin 2–3 times a day.

Remedy 2 Apply chickweed ointment, cream, or freshly squeezed juice up to 5 times a day.

Option Add 2 drops of peppermint oil to 1 tsp of any of the chickweed preparations.

Herb Gotu kola (*Centella asiatica*, p. 76)

Remedy Dust the affected area with powder 2–3 times a day. Alternatively, mix the powder with enough water to make a thick paste and spread over the affected area 1–2 times a day.

Eczema with Weeping Skin

Herb Witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102)

Remedy Apply lotion or cream up to 5 times a day (the lotion is preferable). Alternatively, make a decoction with 2 tsp of leaves to ¾ cup

(150 ml) of water. Leave for 15 minutes, strain, and cool. Use as a wash up to 5 times a day.

Herb German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

Remedy Make an infusion using 50 g of herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Apply directly to the itchy area when cool, or add the hot infusion to a warm bath and soak in it for at least 20 minutes.

Herb Oats (*Avena sativa*, p. 175)

Remedy Fill a muslin (or similar) bag with milled oats and place under a hot tap while running a bath. Relax in the bath for 5–10 minutes.